communal question as a conservative reaction to the progressive forces. Employing religious identities as the primary drivers in politics as Jinnah did with his Muslim League had made him ‘petty-minded’. It had also distracted him ‘from the real problems of the country’.[11]

These fundamental problems were of an economic kind and related to exploitative capitalism. Over much of the past two centuries, Nehru explained, capitalism had ‘helped add to the wealth of the world’. But it had outstayed its welcome after fulfilling its function and as opposed to benefiting society, capitalism had become ‘a terror to further progress’. The main reason for this terror that capitalism had brought about was the uneven distribution of wealth. For Nehru, socialism could cure the inequality in wealth that capitalist modernity had ushered in. All the wealth that capitalism had created required fair redistribution. For this to occur, the ‘abnormal condition’ of British imperialism had to end immediately.[12] There were two ways that imperialism could end: in an ‘orderly way’, through a constitutional transfer of power, or a ‘chaotic way’ that involved some form of revolutionary uprising.[13]

As the transformations capitalism ushered in were global in reach and not limited to a single country alone, any seeker of political wisdom needed to examine the phenomena in an international context. Nehru compared the British occupation of India to the Austria-Hungarian empire of the nineteenth century. Just like Austria’s sudden disintegration, British imperialism too would soon shrink to a mere ‘page in a big book’.[14]

Nehru also voiced grave concerns regarding the upcoming provincial elections under the newly reformed colonial Constitution, the Government of India Act, 1935. While the Congress would participate in those elections, once elected, it would use the gained power to destroy the system of imperial governance. As Nehru emphasized in several speeches given in Lahore in the early months of 1936, the battle for freedom would not come through occupying seats in an imperial council – it would be won ‘in the fields, in the factories, and in the bazaars’.[15]